Bradley Allen
WR121, 10:30-12:20
Daniel Couch
9 March 2022

Research Essay

"Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space lies your freedom and power to choose your response. In those responses lie your growth and happiness" (Covey, qtd. in Croce). This line from Stephen R. Covey, author of *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*, articulates a truth that defines the human experience: humans possess the ability to make an informed decision. But it is also the case that emotions can override cognition. Emotions cloud judgment, and judgment affects decision making. For example, most schools in the United States participate in active shooter drills, even though the chances of a public-school student being killed by a gun at school is 1 in 614,000,000 (Ropeik). Therefore, it is reasonable to assume emotions are the primary rationale for active-shooter drills. The decision to use active-shooter drills was likely made with the best of intentions, but it is causing emotional harm that may predict the sort of behavior it attempts to alleviate.

On May 21, 1998, the United States was rocked by news of a shooting at Thurston High School in Springfield, OR that saw two dead and twenty-five wounded (Schulberg). One year later, in Littleton, CO, another mass shooting took place at Columbine High School, where two students killed 13 and wounded more than 20 others (History.com Editors). In the two decades since Thurston and Columbine, the Center for Homeland Defense and Security, a division of the Naval Postgraduate School that tracks school-related shootings, found that 327 students and teachers have been killed with another 916 wounded (Center for Homeland Defense). Make no mistake, fear of school shootings is not unfounded. For the friends and families of those killed or

wounded, these fears have been realized. Rightfully, Americans witnessing these tragedies have demanded change.

When fearful constituents demand change, institutions respond. A 2019 poll from the Pew Research Center found that more than half of teen students "Worry a shooting could happen at their school," a worry that 63% of parents share (Graf). A majority consensus like this rarely happens in America, and the education system has taken notice. The common response to these fears is to prepare students for the worst. In 2017, the U.S. Department of Education published a report on school crime and safety showing that 95% of schools drilled students on lockdown procedures (Musu-Gilette 118). As with most issues in the United States, private industry observed the potential for market space and jumped at the opportunity to contribute.

With protocols observed in over 5,500 American K-12 school districts, no other company has a more prominent role in student safety than ALICE Training Institute ("ALICE Training FAQ"). ALICE – an acronym for Alert, Lockdown, Inform, Counter, and Evacuate – provides training for situations involving an active-shooter "To help you do everything you can to save yourself and others" ("What Does"). Training methods from the ALICE Training Institute (ALICE) are so ubiquitous that they have earned the imprimatur of multiple government agencies. According to ALICE's website, the US Department of Education, the Department of Homeland Security, and FEMA use ALICE's "Protocols… almost exclusively in all new guidance" ("Debunking"). Directly or indirectly, ALICE's guidance is informing a significant portion of American teachers and, by extension, American students.

Fortunately for fearful parents, ALICE's methods show promising results. In their flier, "ALICE Strategies at Work," ALICE provides a series of testimonials about the effectiveness of their training. The testimonials account for a dozen incidents that occurred over a five-year

period - 2013 to 2018 - at a range of elementary, middle, and high schools. The leading example of when ALICE claims their life saving training had an effect is the Marjory Stoneman Douglas High School shooting, where "A student called his mother on the phone. She recalled her ALICE training and instructed… her son to run" at which point he evacuated from the school without harm (1). These testimonials do not count the number of lives saved, rather, they illustrate frequency and necessity. That is, during the five years included, there were about two incidents per year where ALICE's training was found to be beneficial, providing sufficient reason to believe that without their guidance, lives would have been lost. These anecdotes help assuage fear because they demonstrate real results. But with great market share comes great accountability.

These drills "May be worthwhile, if it were clear that [they] save lives" claims James Hamblin, M.D., in an article for *The Atlantic* titled, "What Are Active-Shooter Drills Doing to Kids?" Hamblin argues that active-shooter drills create an illusion of safety rather than offer true results. "An active-shooter drill… signal[s] to parents and the community that the school is being proactive – it [is] doing *something*." He evinces this argument by drawing attention to a lack of evidence. It is "all but impossible" for studies to establish "Whether active-shooter drills actually prevent harm," says Hamblin. Without definitive evidence for their success, Hamblin shifts to what the evidence really shows, which is active-shooter drills disrupt a child's "Mental and physical health later in life – as well as emotional wellbeing, and the formation of… coping mechanisms." Hamblin does not forecast how these results will impact the future of children. Instead, he is leveraging an emotional appeal to raise awareness for what he believes to be the true purpose behind the drills. They cater to "institutional concern for reputation risk

management" (Hamblin). This claim makes it sound like active-shooter drills are simply liability insurance masquerading as safety.

Hamblin is not the only one thinking about safety in terms of liability. Third on ALICE's list of frequently asked questions is "Will we be held liable… for using ALICE training?" The answer:

> While no one can guarantee a lawsuit will not follow any critical incident, the strong defense of following the "best practices" and "standard-of-care" that is called for by our federal and state guidelines is what a reasonable court/jury would expect. It certainly puts us in a better position of defense then [sic] if we were NOT aligning with those recommendations. ("ALICE Training FAQ")

For this to be a frequently asked question of a leader in active shooting drills suggests that Hamblin is on to *something*. ALICE, it seems, has decided that preparation is meant to establish "best practices" and "standard-of-care" in court, not safety for children in schools. After all, the question could very well have asked whether active-shooter drills benefit children or whether they add to trauma, but it did not.

Leaving nothing to interpretation, ALICE makes their sales pitch explicit. While addressing whether there is "Evidence that ALICE Training makes schools safe," ALICE redirects to liability, claiming insurance industries "See the benefit of investment." ALICE then takes the opportunity to tout their AM Best award for "expert status." But that is not all. AM Best, according to ALICE, "Rates… companies that… service… the insurance industry, and these ratings are a prestigious standard" ("Debunking"). If a parent were to read this, they might be confused, and rightfully so, because the question was meant to inform them about *how* active-shooter drills make their child safe, not sell them an insurance policy.

Regardless of how ALICE sells themselves, the chief beneficiary of safety related investments is children, and they are no wealthier for it. According to Dr. Laural Williams, chief of psychiatry at Texas Children's Hospital, active-shooter drills are psychologically damaging to children because they instill a "Viewpoint that the world is a scary place," causing them to "See everyone as suspicious," even their fellow classmates. Constant suspicion, warns Williams, "Reinforces society's existing struggles with interpersonal connections" (Williams, qtd. in Shalchi). In essence, suspicion promotes a sense of isolation in children making it hard for them to commit to their school and fellow classmates, which inhibits development of social competence. As it turns out, investments in safety are paid for by making constant withdrawals from the collective emotional bank account of American children. Creating such a deficit is borderline criminal.

A 2010 longitudinal study conducted at the University of Michigan, published in *Youth Services Review* by Suh-Ruu Ou and Arthur Reynolds, titled "Childhood Predictors of Young Adult Male Crime," found reduced commitment to school and lower social competence predict young adult male crime (1104). Ou and Reynolds elaborate that higher "Social competence is significantly associated with lower rates of incarceration" (1104). However, the authors of the study caution against using this information to establish "causal interpretations," which is to say the study establishes correlation, not causation (1104). While that is the case for criminality, the study establishes causation of another sort, and that is cause for reflection.

It might be that educational institutions have been too focused on what they *could* do, that they have lost sight of what they *should* do. Schools *should* provide a safe environment that encourages learning. Unfortunately, active-shooter drills seem to have the opposite effect. According to a *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* study published in 2021 by

ElSherief and colleagues, during a 90-day period following active-shooter drills, social media posts from participating students showed a 39-42% increase in language associated with anxiety, stress, and depression. To arrive at their findings, the authors examined 54 million social media posts from before and after active-shooter drills (1). The implication of the study is that this is no isolated incident among a minority group of students, but it is indicative of the emotional state of a plurality of students. Afraid and unable to connect with others is no way for children to go through school. But active-shooter drills are the *something* that the education system *can* do, so they remain committed to them.

Once again, these drills are especially problematic for young boys. In a lecture titled "How Early Childhood Experience Shapes Child and Culture," Bruce Perry, M.D., Ph.D., and Senior Fellow of the Child Trauma Academy, Houston, TX, says it is common for older children, especially males, to develop "A hyper arousal response… where trauma involves witnessing or playing an active role in [an] event" (2). Perry describes the behavioral response of a child dealing with hyperarousal as defiant, "often displaying hypervigilance, anxiety, panic or increased heart rate" (2). In summary, active-shooter drills are contributing to crisis conditions. Again, this is no way for children to go through school.

What is more, crisis conditions might lead to the sort of problems active-shooter drills aim to eliminate. According to *The Violence Project*, a non-profit, nonpartisan research group funded by the National Institute of Justice to research mass shootings, 98% of school shooters are male, and 87% of shooters are "in crisis prior to shooting." *The Violence Project* defines crisis as including such symptoms as increased agitation, abusive behavior, isolation, and depressed mood ("Key Findings"). If these behaviors sound familiar, they should. They are the

same psychologically damaging responses to active-shooter drills observed by Dr. Williams, Dr. Hamblin, Dr. Perry, and ElSherief.

It is important to note there exists no report linking active-shooter drills to behavior predictive of a school shooter. What the information suggests is that students are fearful enough of school shootings. Piling on to existing fear with active-shooter drills might not be the best solution, especially not for young boys. And certainly not when they are so rare. Until there is a better understanding of the impact active-shooter drills have on the emotional wellbeing of students, it might be best to explore alternative solutions that are less costly, both monetarily and emotionally. Dr. Williams offers a solution that might satisfy both of these conditions. Improving "Social connectivity in schools," she says, reduces "Bullying… increases academic performance and mental health" which "maybe a more potent inoculation against violence than [active-shooter] drills" (Williams, qtd. in Shalchi). Better educated, better connected, and better socialized is *the* way for children to go through school. Best of all, this information provides an opportunity to explore what can be done to improve conditions.

In order to improve one must first see the problem for what it is, then find the best way forward. American's see school shootings as a real threat. ALICE shows that active-shooter drills provide real results. Experts say schools would do better to focus on mental health, not drills. Reason suggests there is room for both. Seeing the light of reason means acknowledging the line between action and overreaction is not only fine, it is also blurred by competing interests. Fortunately, instructions on how best to walk this line have been articulated most succinctly by Jonny Cash in his 1956 hit song, "I Walk the Line," with the following lyrics:

I keep a close watch on this heart of mine

I keep my eyes wide open all the time

I keep the ends out for the tie that binds

Because you're mine, I walk the line (“I Walk the Line”)

While Cash may have been walking the line for the sake of romantic fidelity, lines exist wherever one may draw them. For active-shooter drills, the line is drawn between emotion and cognition. Fidelity to American school children demands everyone with something (in this case, someone) at stake keep their eyes wide open, their heart in check, and pursue policy that brings people closer together, what Cash described as “the tie that binds.” Or, as Covey might have put it, Americans must take advantage of the space between emotion and response to choose growth and happiness.

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